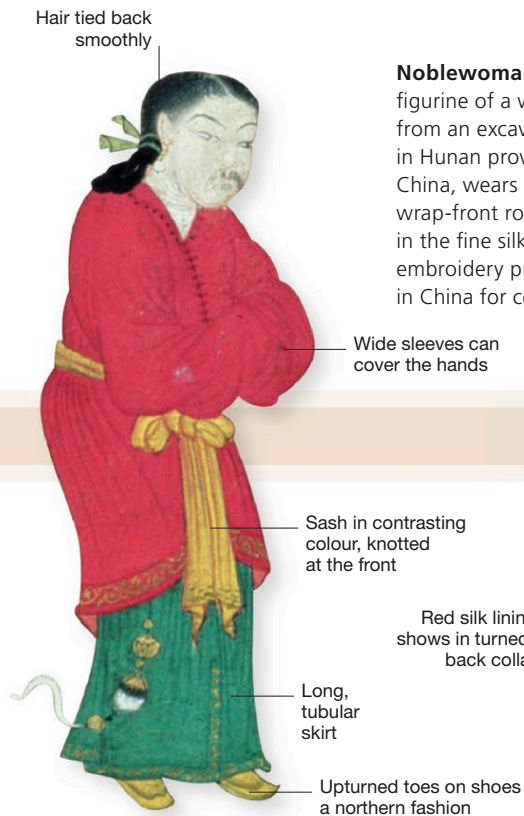




Noblewoman A figurine of a woman from an excavated tomb in Hunan province, China, wears a white silk wrap-front robe covered in the fine silk floral embroidery practised in China for centuries.



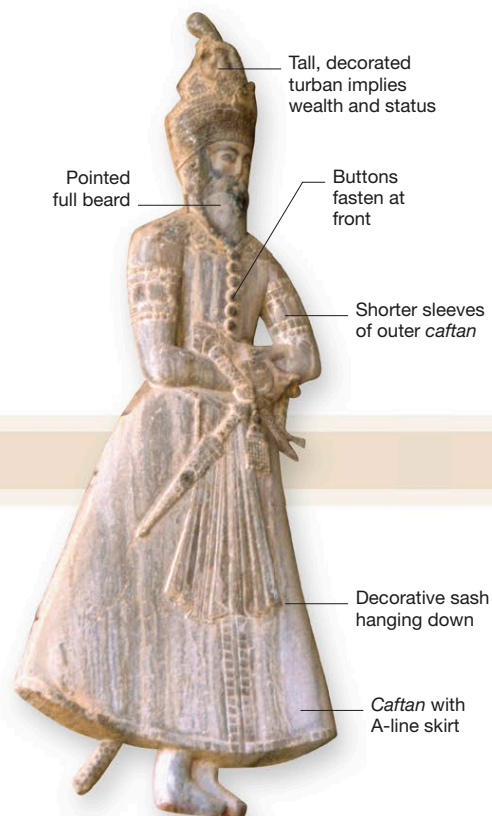
Kimono's origins The distinctive, loose T-shape of the garment later called a kimono is apparent in this Chinese man's outfit. Men's and women's clothing were similar. Japan adopted clothing from the Chinese Han Dynasty early in the Common Era.

SILK ROAD

The Silk Road was not one but several trading routes through the mountains and deserts between Asia, the Arabian peninsula, and the Mediterranean. Silk was a prime commodity, along with precious stones and spices. Excavations along the Silk Road offer glimpses into the cloths being traded. For example, at Palmyra in Syria – a major trading centre that handled goods from China, India, and Iran in the Roman period – Chinese silks have been found in tombs.

After Western cultures fell for silk's allure, their goal was to learn the secrets of sericulture (obtaining silk from silkworms) for themselves. The Persians succeeded by the 3rd century CE.

Western Han Dynasty silk banner, c.180BCE, found in a tomb in Hunan province, China



Ancient Persian This Sassanid-era (200–600CE) nobleman wears a tall hat and wide-skirted *caftan* (robe). The tailoring is sophisticated – it is fitted and has tight sleeves. Persians wore silk two centuries before the Byzantines.



Sassanid noble Horse-riding tribes originally cut curved fitted clothes from skins, rather than straight woven lengths. Clothes convenient for riding – long sleeves, split skirts, and shaped waists – became the norm.